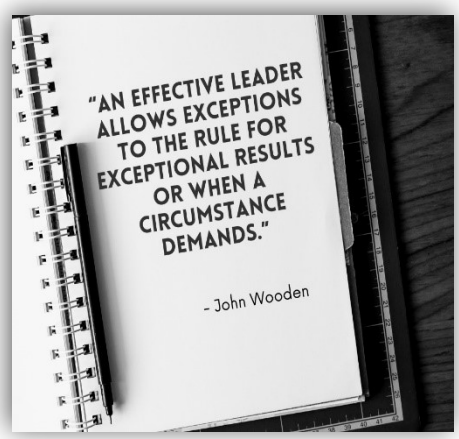
Leadership Tool: Utilizing the Powerful Benefits of Flexibility in Hybrid Work

One indispensable tool in the arsenal of effective leadership, especially when it comes to leading in a hybrid work environment, is flexibility. The world of work is consistently changing and so are the demands on leaders to address varying circumstances, tailor approaches to effectively lead individual team members and pivot strategies in response to unforeseen opportunities. The use of flexibility not only enhances a leader's effectiveness in addressing this landscape but also fosters a culture of agility, resilience, and continuous improvement within their team and organization. The following article discusses the importance of flexibility as a leadership tool, when it might be beneficial to employ flexibility in one's leadership, and 12 questions you can ask as a leader than will help determine if flexibility is right in a particular situation.

Importance of Flexibility as a Leadership Tool

The power and importance of flexibility is particularly evident when it comes to decision-making. Leaders who know when to be flexible and when to be ridged in their decision-making efforts are better equipped to navigate the complexities of modern business, especially in a hybrid work culture. These leaders can balance the need for quick, decisive action with the understanding that patience and adaptability can, at times, lead to better long-term outcomes. In this leadership style, flexibility allows the leader's strategies to be as multifaceted as the challenges they aim to address. This flexible, multifaceted approach allows leaders to respond to shifting market demands, technological advancements, evolving workforce expectations, and empower a team of individuals with different needs.



In line with empowering individuals is the impact flexibility can have on enhancing team morale and engagement. Leaders who demonstrate flexibility show that they value their employees' impute and are willing to consider, for the best of the employee and the organization, how to adapt to better suit their team's needs and strengths. When utilizing flexibility appropriately it not only empowers employees but also fosters a workplace environment where creativity/innovation, communication, and care, can flourish. Additionally, by being flexible, leaders create a more inclusive and supportive atmosphere that accommodates diverse work styles and supports personal/professional growth.

Finally, flexibility also allows leaders to better manage the complexities of individuals working in a hybrid work environment. While each employee has different strengths and needs, this is only heightened when you apply a hybrid work environment to a team. Recognizing that each hybrid work employee may have different motivators, challenges, and preferences requires leaders to utilize a flexible approach to leadership. Tailoring feedback, support, and recognition

to fit the unique needs of employees working hybrid can lead to higher levels of job satisfaction, loyalty and performance. While it may require more from the leader to apply flexibility in their practice, this personalized leadership demonstrates a commitment to the well-being and success of every member of the team. At the end, this tool of flexibility cultivates a sense of trust and respect that is fundamental for effect team collaboration. Yet, even with all the wonderful outputs of a leader who uses flexibility appropriately, it is critical to hold firm when appropriate.

When to Utilize the Tool of Leadership Flexibility

One of the challenges of effective leadership is determining when to be more rigid or more flexible when making decisions. The following are some key considerations leaders should be aware of to make informed decisions about when to adopt a flexible approach and when to maintain consistency.

The Flexible Leader the Context Needs You to Be

Each situation is unique, leaders should take time to evaluate the circumstances and the stakes involved. Flexibility is often beneficial in situations that require creativity/innovation and/or are new/untested. In contrast, consistency with past ways of doing things is often necessary when dealing with compliance, legal requirements, or safety protocols where there is little room for error. Additionally, leaders will need to recognize when a situation calls for feedback and consensus-building or when decisive action is needed. However, it is critical to point out that if leaders utilize a more collaborative style, it is important that they use flexibility to make decisions. Having employees engage in the process to only make a ridged decision, different than the team's suggestion, can have a negative impact on engagement and productivity.

In context where team dynamics are at play, understanding your team's capabilities, work ethic, and level of trust can determine how much flexibility you should provide. A seasoned team with a strong track record is the perfect example of individuals who may thrive with a more flexible approach. On the other hand, newer or less experienced individuals or teams might require more structure found in a ridged approach. Often, increased flexibility by a leader allows greater autonomy to make decisions about their work processes, schedules, and methods. While it is still critical to have open communication and specific accountability measures, even in more seasoned teams, this increase flexibility can lead to increases in job satisfaction, creativity, and ownership of work.

The Flexible Leader You Need You to Be

While context may dictate when you should utilize flexibility as a leadership tool, another indicator is based on the leader. It is important for leaders to be aware of their natural tendencies toward flexibility or rigidity and how these tendencies impact decision making. Being aware of your bias towards flexibility or rigidity can help in balancing these tendencies appropriately. Additionally, leaders need to consider, based on their values, the type of leader they want to be. Flexibility can play a significant

role in a leader achieving several different leadership practices (driven by their values) including:

- Increasing Productivity: It is important for leaders to consider how flexibility will impact productivity. While increases in flexibility can boost morale and creativity (leading to increases in productivity), in some cases, too much flexibility can cause confusion and a lack of direction.
- Encouraging Work-Life Balance: Demonstrating flexibility in supporting the varying personal needs of your employees can have a positive impact on work-life balance, leading to more engaged and motivated employees. However, having too few boundaries may make it difficult for teams to communicate and work together.
- Supporting Growth and Development: Staying flexible in supporting the career paths and developmental needs of team members is imperative to their growth. By allowing them to adjust roles or responsibilities to align with their career aspirations will certainly bring about passion for their job. However, with increased flexibility comes increased time required to address the previous jobs of the employee who has been granted the flexibility.

Effective leaders spend time determining how they can use flexibility to emphasize those leadership practices that match their values. While it is often easier to just say "no" or do it the way it has always been done, if appropriate, pushing against these established (real or perceived) boundaries can highlight what a leader values and allows them to lead by example.

The Flexible Leader the Organization Needs You to Be

Finally, the organization will dictate how flexible you can be. First, hopefully it goes without saying that your flexibility will be dictated by the policies of the organization. In addition to these policies, a good place to find answers for your level of flexibility can be found in the organizational values. If flexibility or innovation is a core value of your organization, then a flexible approach supports these values. However, if the organization priorities consistency and reliability, a rigid approach might be warranted. Another, not as obvious source to find answers on whether to increase flexibility can be found in feedback from different stakeholders both inside and outside the organization. By being politically savvy in your role, you should be able to understand all types of feedback and cultural currents that dictate your level of flexibility.

Twelve Lighthouse Questions

A lighthouse serves as a navigational aid, emitting a powerful light that guides ships to their destination while avoiding hazards. Similarly, these following 12 questions look to illuminate your path in utilizing flexibility as a tool in hybrid work. Additionally, just as sailors rely on the lighthouse to signal safe passage and warn of impending dangers, these questions look to inform you of potential challenges and provide guidance. Finally, a lighthouse is equipped to adjust its light's intensity based on the visibility conditions, demonstrating adaptability. Utilizing the 12 questions below will require you, as an effective leader, to determine the level of flexibility that is appropriate for

any given situation. If you are having difficulty determining whether or not to utilize the power of flexibility, turn to these questions to guide your way.

Question 1: What is the nature of the issue that may require flexibility?

Is this a high stakes situation where adherence to rules or policies are necessary or is there room for flexibility without significant consequences?

Question 2: In this situation, has the employee(s) demonstrated reliability, responsibility, and accountability in the past?

Past behavior is a good prediction of future behavior and may be a wonderful indicator on how they would handle increased flexibility moving forward. If the past behavior does not indicate this level of trust a more structured approach will be needed.

Question 3: What are both the risks and benefits of being flexible in this situation?

Does increased flexibility lead to the possibility of innovation and improved morale or is there a greater likelihood that it could result in confusion, missed deadlines, or other negative outcomes for the employee/team?

Question 4: Does the request for flexibility in this situation align with the team's/organization's values and/or goals?

Could granting flexibility in this situation work to the team/organization's broader objectives or goals? Or does this flexibility set a precedent that could undermine team cohesion or organizational standards?

Question 5: How will this flexibility impact the culture the leader (or the organization) is trying to build?

Would choosing flexibility or rigidity in this situation reinforce the culture the leader is trying to build? How might this decision to be flexible be perceived by the team in terms of fairness?

Question 6: Would the leader be comfortable setting this as a precedent for others who might ask for this flexibility?

Is this decision to be flexible, sustainable, and replicable over time? Does this decision create expectations that the leader cannot consistently meet?

Question 7: How does being flexible in this particular situation reinforce the values I espouse as a leader?

Does this decision to be (or not to be) flexible in this situation align with the core principles and ethics of my leadership? Is this a decision I would be comfortable talking about with other leaders in the organization, so they had a better understanding of my leadership values?

Question 8: Will being ridged or flexible about my decision contribute more to the employee's growth and development?

Is the employee more likely to build skills, gain confidence, and progress in their career if I am more flexible/ridged? How is the decision I make about being more ridged/flexible more likely to lead to this growth and development?

Question 9: How will the decision I make about being flexible/ridged impact the trust and rapport I have with the employee and the team?

Is it more likely that a decision to be flexible, adaptive, and supportive will strengthen my relationship with the employee/team or is it necessary to maintain boundaries and standards to ensure clarity, respect, and authority?

Question 10: Is this a unique situation or could providing flexibility lead to this becoming a recurring issue?

Does the decision in this situation lead to a pattern of behavior and have I thought about how I will handle this situation in the future? What assurances do I have that this will be a onetime occurrence and not a reoccurring issue?

Question 11: What external factors might be influencing my decision on being more or less flexible?

Are there pressures or constraints coming from the broader business environment or stakeholders that are impacting my judgement on how I should move forward? Should these external factors influence my decision?

Question 12: How will I both communicate and enforce my decision?

What are the necessary steps I will need to take to ensure that the decision is understood, accepted, and implemented? Additionally, how will I handle any feedback or resistance on this decision (keeping in mind best practices of effective leadership)?

Conclusion

In the end, whether you are opting for flexibility or rigidity in your decision-making process, make sure that the decision is clearly communicated to the team, along with the rationale behind it. This clarity and transparency will go a long way in preventing any misunderstandings and aligning the team with your leadership approach. Since the world of work has changed significantly, especially in a hybrid environment, remember it is important to continue to adjust your leadership style as new information comes to light or as the situation changes.